

India Emerging Consumer

India Food Delivery: Lessons from China's expensive (\$30 Bn) war for market share ...



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India's food delivery space is seeing increasing attempts to disrupt the duopoly of Zomato and Swiggy. We look at the experience of China when Meituan's leadership was challenged by JD and Alibaba and what possible lessons exist for Indian players.

China's food delivery market is far deeper than India's. India's eating out market size is 1/12th of China's and the food delivery market is even smaller at 1/22nd of China's. Despite this apparent early stage of evolution, the food delivery market share has largely been stable across top-2 players for the last few years. The stability in turn has translated into strong unit economics and high market caps, attracting competition.

Despite this scale difference, India FD players have higher margins than China. At peak, Meituan (~75% China FD mkt. share) had a 3.9% operating margin vs. 4.6% for Zomato. A key reason for better margins in India is that India FD players only service the high-income consumers. The per-capita-adjusted-AOV for India (AOV of \$5 vs GDP-per-capita of \$2,500) is much higher than China (\$7 vs \$14,000 resp.). When you service the top-of-pyramid customers, the revenue/ commission rates are driven by income of that cohort. But the cost to serve is driven by the average per-capita income. The bigger this gap between the 'revenue-generating cohort' and 'cost cohort', the greater the margin profile, structurally.

The China food delivery war: \$30bn spent in the name of... what? The food delivery market in China was considered a relatively sheltered space, until slowing e-commerce growth drove convergence between Meituan as the quick commerce leader, and e-commerce incumbents Alibaba and JD. Almost \$30bn spent later, Meituan has retained its leadership position in the higher value end of the market. But the act of delivering goods in 30 minutes has become available on multiple platforms, and the low-end market has become a user traffic acquisition channel for the e-commerce platforms. Strategically, the convergence of food delivery, quick e-commerce, and e-commerce in China looks permanent to us.

The implications for Indian food delivery. The magnitude of spend required to dislodge Meituan's near-monopoly on instant delivery was probably a testament to the *strength* of its prior moat, rather than the reverse. It remains to be seen whether the management desire to incinerate shareholder capital in the name of market share will translate well to India. Greater competition points to lower industry margins, and losers become clear long before new winners emerge. But at least today, the Indian pretenders simply lack the profit engines that funded the China conflict. For incumbents Zomato and Swiggy, this likely implies a more gradual rise in competitive intensity from new entrants rather than the fall-off-the-cliff market share change that was indicative of the bloodbath in China.

Hence, the key question for Indian FD challengers remains ... for what? Given the shallow nature of the food services market in India, even if a solution to profitable food delivery is found for the low-AOV businesses, it is unlikely to expand the TAM as the TAM limitation (for both food services and food delivery) is more cultural and economical. Even if a solution is found for low-AOV demand, it is likely to lead to a structurally decreasing margin profile.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			9 Sep 2026		TTM	Reported EPS				Reported P/E (x)		
			Closing	Price	Rel.							
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2026A	2027E	2028E	2026A	2027E	2028E
ETERNAL.IN (Eternal)	O	INR	320.60	350.00	(31.6)%	INR	0.40	1.01	3.34	801.5	316.0	95.9
SWIGGY.IN (Swiggy)	O	INR	282.75	430.00	(63.7)%	INR	(16.87)	(10.45)	(2.84)	(16.8)	(27.0)	(99.7)
ASIAX			1,998.05									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

The Indian food delivery space looks ripe for disruption on paper, as we have written about earlier ([LINK](#)). Access to high-frequency touchpoint with the consumer, a healthy margin profile, structural growth prospects will all ensure that the industry keeps looking attractive to investors. And hence, either an existing digital commerce player or a challenger may keep emerging.

If the intent is to unlock demand at a lower price point and include more consumers into food delivery space, the challenger needs to solve 3 structural issues simultaneously -

(1) Food service demand in India is itself shallow, with only \$50-60 per capita per year of spend on average, due to cultural and affordability reasons. Any effort which assumes a rapid change at the industry level (which could then need to be driven by cultural changes) is unlikely to succeed quickly.

(2) The lower AOV demand is also concentrated in larger cities - putting a floor on how low the cost of customer acquisition and servicing can go to support the lower AOV demand.

(3) Lower commission rate alone is not enough to build a sustainable alternative business model. It will require a fundamental change in the cost structure, which is much tougher to achieve.

As of now, we don't see a convincing answer to these 3 points as an alternative food delivery business model. In a long-enough run, we see new players will continue to try to address this space and keep competition always on the horizon. However, the key benefit for Eternal and Swiggy today is that the size of the prize is small. Even if Food Delivery business model can be innovated, the depth of the overall food services market itself is very low - with AOVs of <INR 150-175 (<\$2) and low frequency of eating outside. Until that changes materially, the depth that an alternate business model could see remains limited.

Without concrete answers, the impact of increased competitive intensity may grow only gradually and remain muted.

We retain our estimates and Outperform rating for the incumbents Eternal and Swiggy as having the best position to fend off any competition.

DETAILS

India's food delivery space is seeing increasing attempts to disrupt the duopoly of Eternal and Swiggy. China saw exactly this play out over 2025-26 when JD and Alibaba challenged Meituan's leadership. In this note, we compare the two markets - and why they are different, trace how the China food delivery war unfolded and what it means for the Indian incumbents.

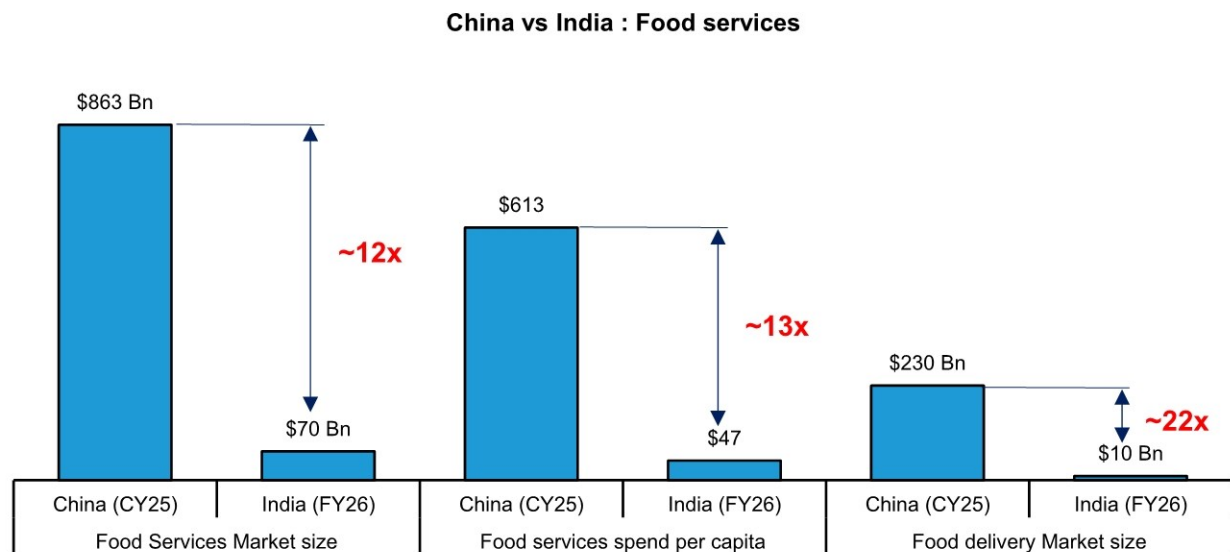
INDIA'S FOOD SERVICES AND FOOD DELIVERY MARKETS ARE DEEPLY UNDER-PENETRATED VS CHINA'S

The scale gap : 12x on food services, 22x on food delivery : China's food services market is ~\$863 Bn (CY25) vs ~\$70 Bn for India (FY26). Food services spend per capita is ~13x (\$613 vs \$47). The gap is even wider in food delivery, where China's ~\$230 Bn market is ~22x of India's ~\$10 Bn market ([Exhibit 1](#)). Both countries have similar population levels and therefore the gap is entirely income and eating out behavior. When JD and Alibaba attacked Meituan, they were fighting for a share of ~\$230 Bn market whereas a challenger in India is fighting for a share of ~\$10 Bn market. Therefore, a larger market size justifies a larger war.

China is a mature, stable-growth market. India is growing faster, but consumer behavior is changing slowly : China's food services market grew from \$636 Bn to \$863 Bn over FY18-25, a ~4.5% CAGR ([Exhibit 2](#)) while India grew at ~7.5% CAGR over FY18-26, from ~\$39 Bn to ~\$70 Bn ([Exhibit 3](#)). India's higher growth rate is the expected story for an under-penetrated market. The concerning part is that India's food services growth is still not outpacing overall consumption expenditure growth. Eating out is gaining wallet share but very gradually. The per-capita wallet makes this structural gap even clearer. Chinese consumers spend ~4.5% of GDP on food services, spending ~\$613 per capita annually ([Exhibit 4](#)). For India, it is <2% of GDP and ~\$47 per capita ([Exhibit 5](#)). This is a function of affordability/income and food culture (home cooked meals remain the default in India). A Chinese consumer spends ~\$1,280 a year on food and allocates ~\$613 of it to eating out, roughly half the food wallet ([Exhibit 6](#)). An Indian consumer spends ~\$330 a year on food and allocates only ~\$47 to food services, a ~15% share. So, a 13x food services gap is really a ~4x income/spending gap multiplied by a ~3x behavior gap ([Exhibit 7](#)).

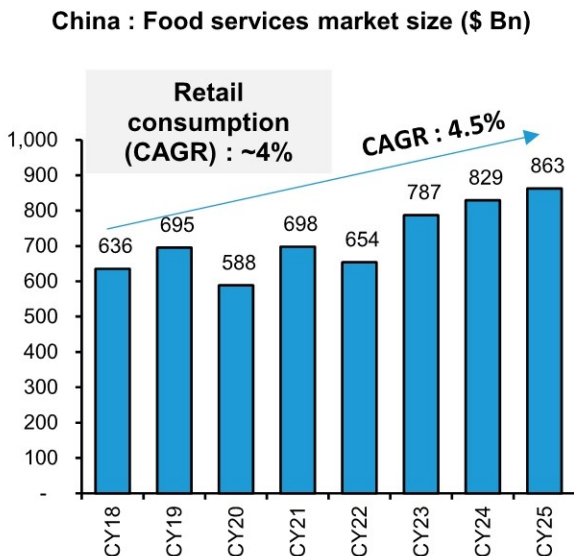
Food delivery penetration: ~27% of food services in China vs ~15% in India : Within food services, delivery has gone much deeper in China at ~27% share in FY25 vs ~10% in FY18 ([Exhibit 8](#)). India is at ~15% (FY26) and share gain has been steady at 100-150 bps per year for the last several years ([Exhibit 9](#)). The real constraint in India is not the online shift but eating out behavior itself. The overall food services market is growing very slowly in India. China's delivery boom rode on a large and growing eating out culture. India does not have that tailwind yet. So India's path to deeper penetration will be gradual driven by income growth and changing habits.

EXHIBIT 1: India's food services and food delivery markets are deeply under-penetrated vs. China's



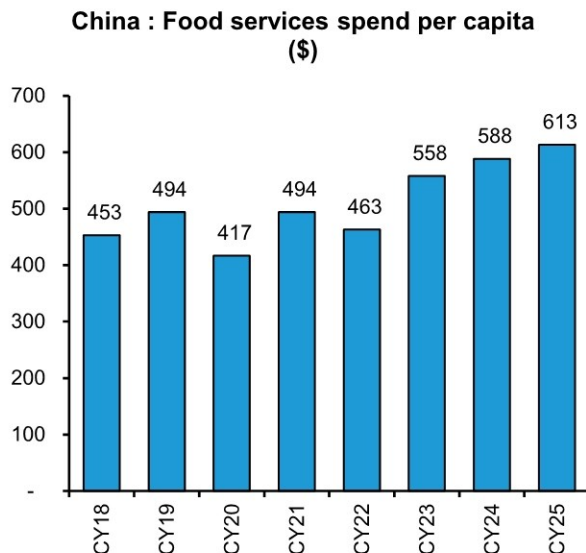
Source: NRAI, National Bureau of Statistics China, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 2: China Food Services: A large, relatively mature market with stable growth CAGR of 4.5% over last 7 years, marginally faster than consumption expenditure growth



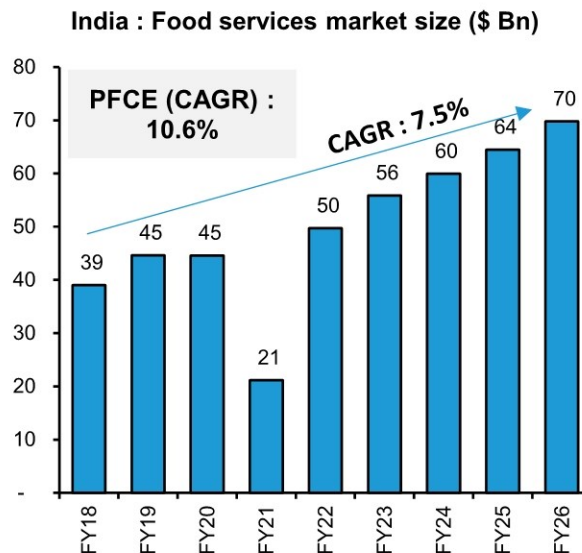
Source: National Bureau of Statistics China, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: China: ~4.5% of GDP per capita is towards food services spend, and is growing



Source: National Bureau of Statistics China, World Bank, Bernstein analysis

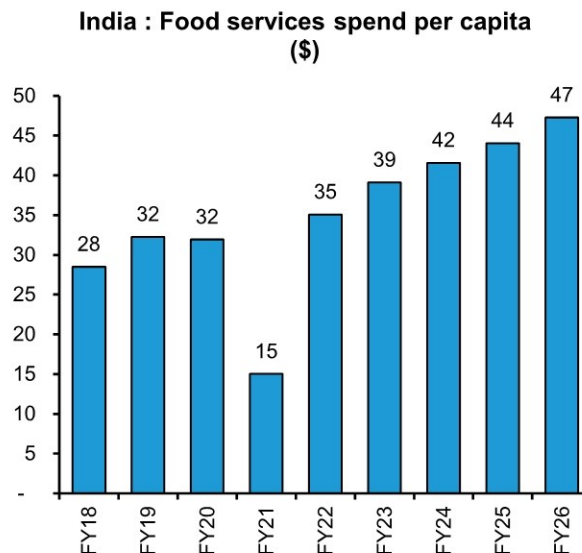
EXHIBIT 3: India Food Services: Higher growth, but still not outpacing private final consumption expenditure growth, indicating slow consumer behavior change



*USD/INR exchange rate used for conversion is 95

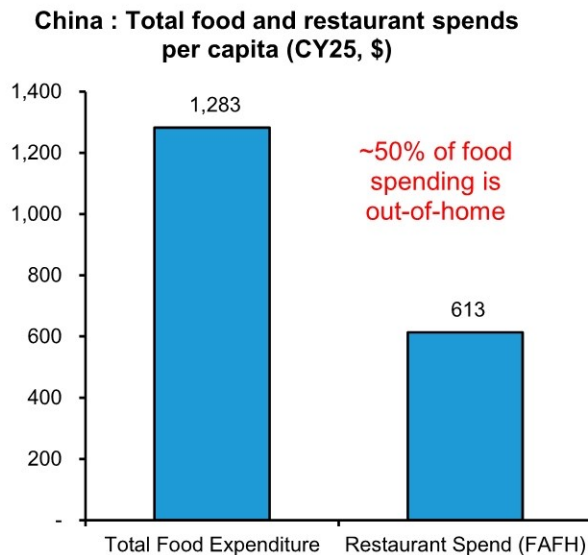
Source: NRAI, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 5: India: <2% of GDP is towards food services spend, and the allocation is not growing

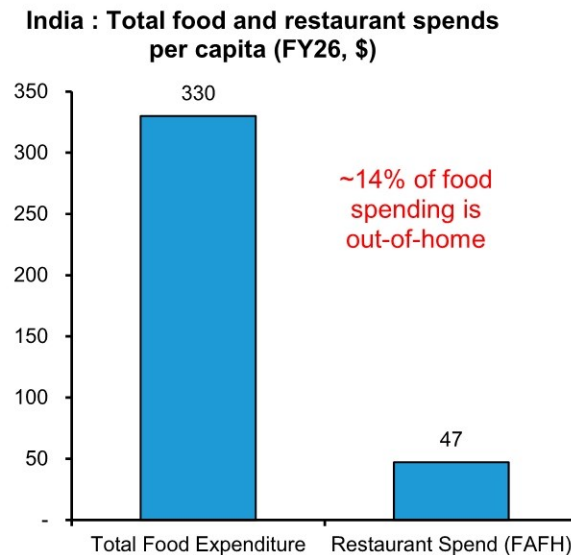


*USD/INR exchange rate used for conversion is 95

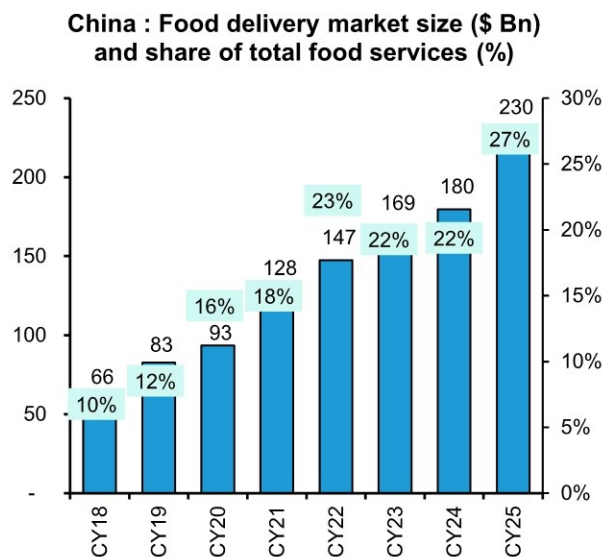
Source: NRAI, UN, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 6: China: Eating out takes ~50% of the food wallet.

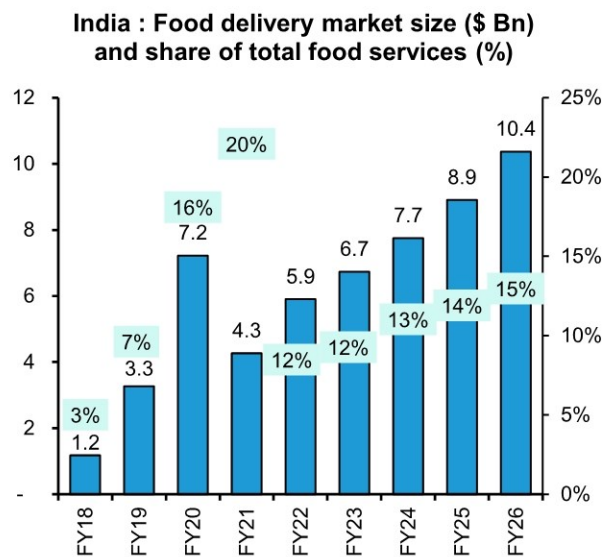
Source: National Bureau of Statistics China, World Bank, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: India: Home cooked meals dominate, food services is ~15% of food spend

Source: NRAI, HCES, World Bank, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 8: China: Food delivery has penetrated deeper into food services, at 27% share

Source: National Bureau of Statistics China, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: India: Food services growth into food services has been consistent at 100-150 bps per year

*USD/INR exchange rate used for conversion is 95

Source: Company reports, NRAI, Bernstein analysis and estimates

INDIA'S FOOD DELIVERY PROFITABILITY MATCHES MEITUAN'S BEST QUARTER, DESPITE THE SCALE DIFFERENCE

The scale gap is enormous: Meituan's food delivery GTV (Mar'26 qtr annualized) is ~\$164 Bn vs ~\$6 Bn for Zomato (Jun'26 qtr annualized) which is difference of ~29x ([Exhibit 10](#)). The profit gap is similar. Meituan's food delivery operating profit in FY24 (its best year, before the "FD" war) was ~\$4.9 Bn vs ~\$0.2 Bn of Adjusted EBITDA for Zomato in FY26, a ~23x gap ([Exhibit 11](#)).

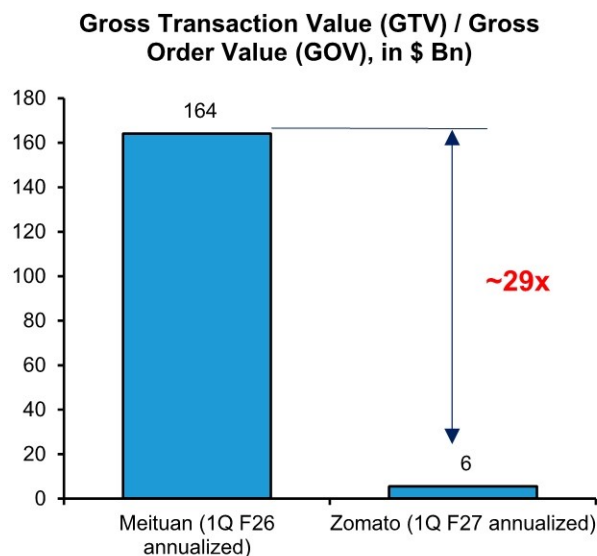
The gap disappears on a per-order basis: Exhibit 12 breaks down Meituan's food delivery unit economics in 2024, its most profitable quarter. On an AOV of ~\$7.2, Meituan earned ~\$0.3 of operating profit per order. This was the peak output of the world's largest food delivery player, running at full efficiency with ~70% market share. Exhibit 13 shows Zomato's 1Q27 unit economics. On an AOV of ~\$5.2 per order, Zomato makes ~\$0.2 of Adjusted EBITDA per order at 1/29th the scale of Meituan. Swiggy also makes similar profit per order (Exhibit 14) despite a lower market share and scale than Zomato.

How is this possible? We believe a key reason for better margins in India is that the platforms have the benefit of servicing only the high-income consumer cohort. The per-capita-adjusted-AOV for India (i.e. an AOV of \$5 vs GDP-per-capita of \$2,500) is much higher than China (i.e. an AOV of \$7 vs GDP per capita of ~\$14,000).

When you service the top-of-pyramid customers, the revenue/ commission rates are driven by income of that cohort. But the cost to serve is driven by the average per-capita income of the country. The bigger this gap between the 'revenue-generating cohort' and 'cost cohort', the better the margin profile, structurally.

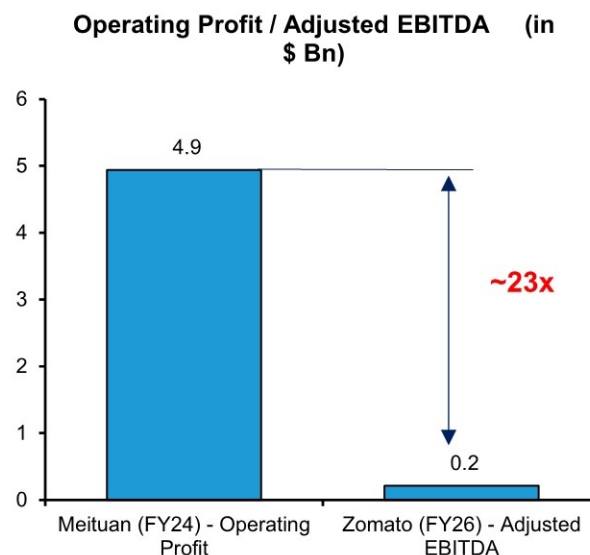
Going forward, it is likely that as India's food delivery market attempts to address demand of lower AOV orders and customers which will lead to a structurally decreasing margin profile while expanding the pool of absolute margin in INR terms.

EXHIBIT 10: Meituan's food delivery GTV is ~29x to that of Zomato's GOV.



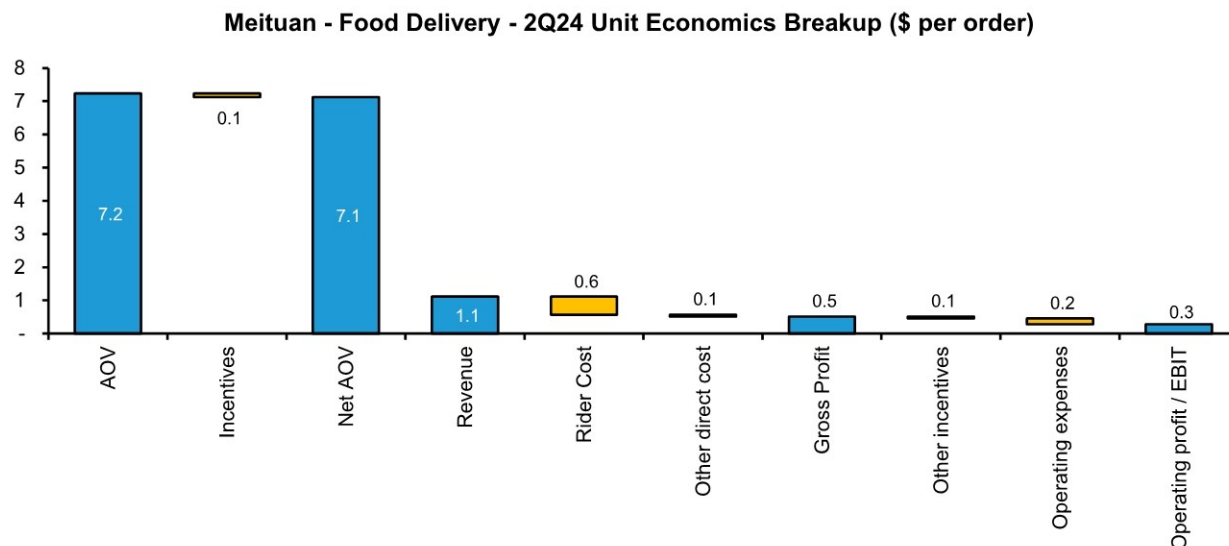
Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 11: The profit gap is also similar, Meituan's operating profit in FY24 (its best year, before the "FD" war) is ~23x of Zomato's FY26 adj. EBITDA



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

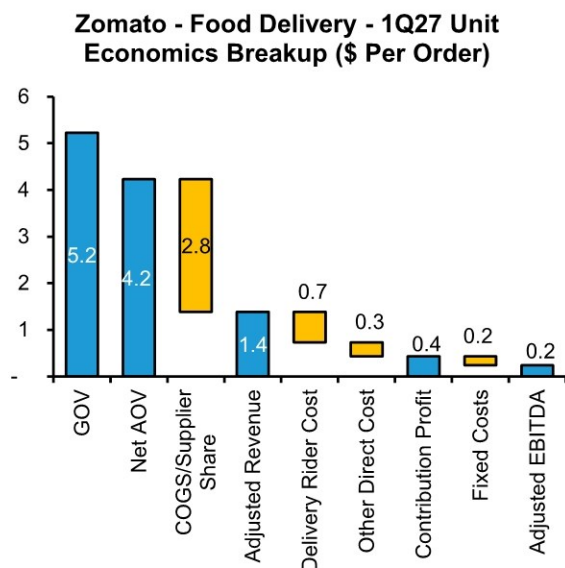
EXHIBIT 12: On an AOV of ~\$7.2, Meituan earned ~\$0.3 of operating profit per order in its best quarter (2Q24) before the “FD” war.



*USD/RMB exchange rate used for conversion is 6.72

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

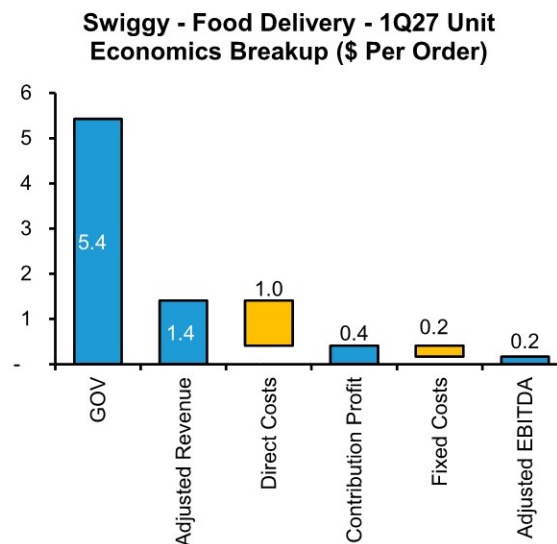
EXHIBIT 13: Zomato: Despite much lower scale, the profit per order is similar to Meituan's profit per order in its best Qtr



*USD/INR exchange rate used for conversion is 95

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 14: Swiggy: Also makes a similar profit per order as Zomato, despite a lower market share and scale



*USD/INR exchange rate used for conversion is 95

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

THE CHINA FD WAR : HOW A 70% MARKET SHARE LEADER LOST ITS PROFIT POOL IN FOUR QUARTERS

The attack came when growth was already slowing : Meituan's GTV and order growth had been decelerating steadily, from 20s post pandemic to mid-teens YoY by 2024 ([Exhibit 15](#)). A maturing category with a dominant, highly profitable leader is a stable structure until someone with deep pockets decides to get a pie of the market. Food delivery's high frequency nature

(at least in China) makes it an attractive customer acquisition engine in e-commerce. This, in our view, may be the core reason why JD and Alibaba started the price war to capture market share. JD entered the food delivery business in Feb'25 with zero commissions for restaurants and with social security schemes for riders. Zero commissions targeted Meituan's revenue while rider social security raised its cost line, forcing the incumbent to defend both sides of the P&L at once. Alibaba escalated the competitive intensity in mid-2025 after merging Ele.me into its core e-commerce app.

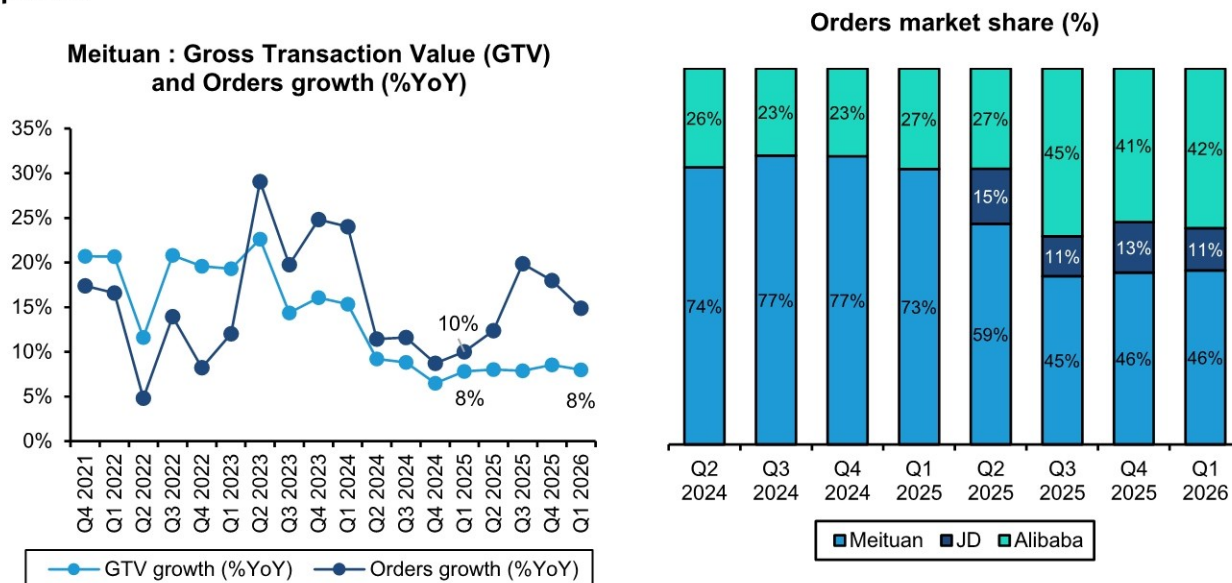
The impact : Meituan lost ~30 pp of order share in about a year : From ~74-77% of order market share through 2024, Meituan's share fell to ~46% by 1Q26 ([Exhibit 16](#)). Alibaba scaled to ~42% and JD settled at ~11%. Note : Alibaba's order count includes its broader quick commerce orders, but the direction of market share loss holds true. A similar trend is seen in rider app DAUs market share ([Exhibit 17](#)). A duopoly like structure became a three-player war within 4 quarters. Scale, brand, rider network and a decade of execution did not prevent the share shift. Consumer subsidies moved the demand to whoever was willing to pay for it.

The P&L damage : [Exhibit 19](#) shows Meituan's food delivery revenue, incentives and operating profit since 2017. The "FD" war resulted in revenue declining from ~16% of GTV to ~14% as fees and commissions were cut to defend merchants and customers. Incentives jumped from ~3% of GTV to ~8%. Operating profit declined from ~2% of GTV to ~6% of GTV. Similar damage on a per-order basis. [Exhibit 20](#) shows the unit economics waterfall for Meituan as of 1Q26. AOV declined from \$7.2 to \$6.9, incentives per order quadrupled from ~\$0.1 to ~\$0.4. Revenue per order fell from \$1.1 to \$0.9 while rider cost rose to ~\$0.7. The ~\$0.3 per order profit of 2Q24 became a ~\$0.1 per order loss as of 1Q26 (it went down to a loss of ~\$0.4 per order in 3Q25).

Industry's total loss : From Q2 2025 to Q2 2026, cumulative operating losses of Meituan, JD and Alibaba stands at ~\$28 Bn ([Exhibit 21](#)). The peak quarter alone saw Alibaba lose of ~\$5.4 Bn. Losses have narrowed meaningfully by Q2 2026 as subsidies cooled, but the cumulative burn of ~\$28 Bn exceeds anything the global food delivery industry has seen. All three players funded this from their large internal cash engines without the need of any external capital to fight. This is one of the biggest difference vs India.

The stock market reaction was brutal for the incumbent : [Exhibit 22](#) shows the stock price movement of the three stocks from Jan'25. Meituan derated sharply as its profit pool evaporated. JD also fell due to its new business loss. Alibaba however saw a rally as its AI and cloud story mattered more than the delivery burn. In a subsidy war, the pure play incumbent has everything to lose while a diversified challenger with another story can still be safe.

EXHIBIT 15: Meituan Food Delivery Order growth has been volatile but GTV growth rate has been stable for last 6-7 quarters **EXHIBIT 16: Rapid introduction of consumer subsidies led to rapid shift in order market share...**

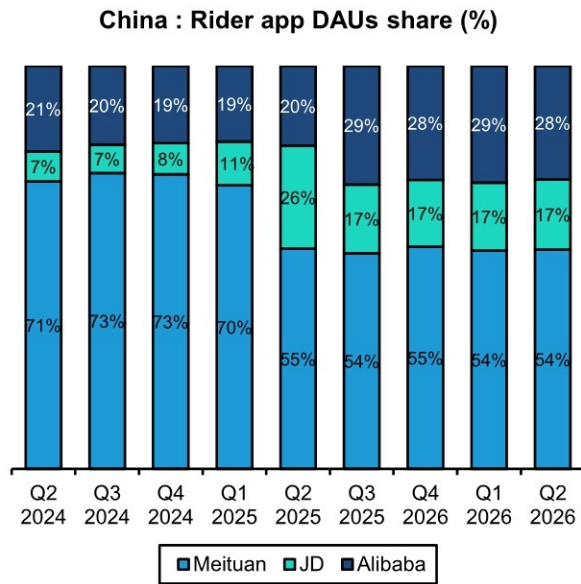


Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

*For Meituan and JD, orders are of the food delivery segment; for Alibaba, total orders are for the broader quick commerce segment, which includes food delivery.

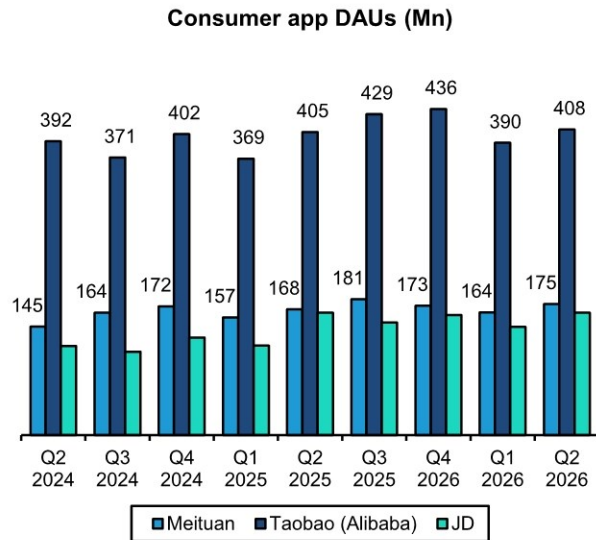
Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 17: ...as well as the Rider app DAU share



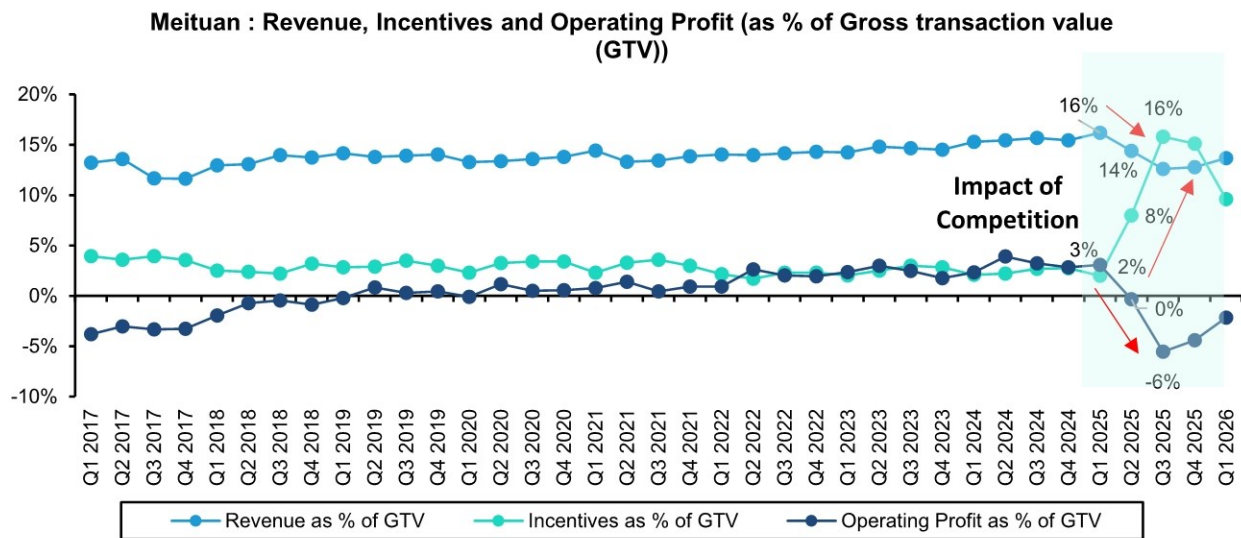
Source: Sensor Tower, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: JD and Alibaba were able to ramp up quickly as their core apps already had large DAU



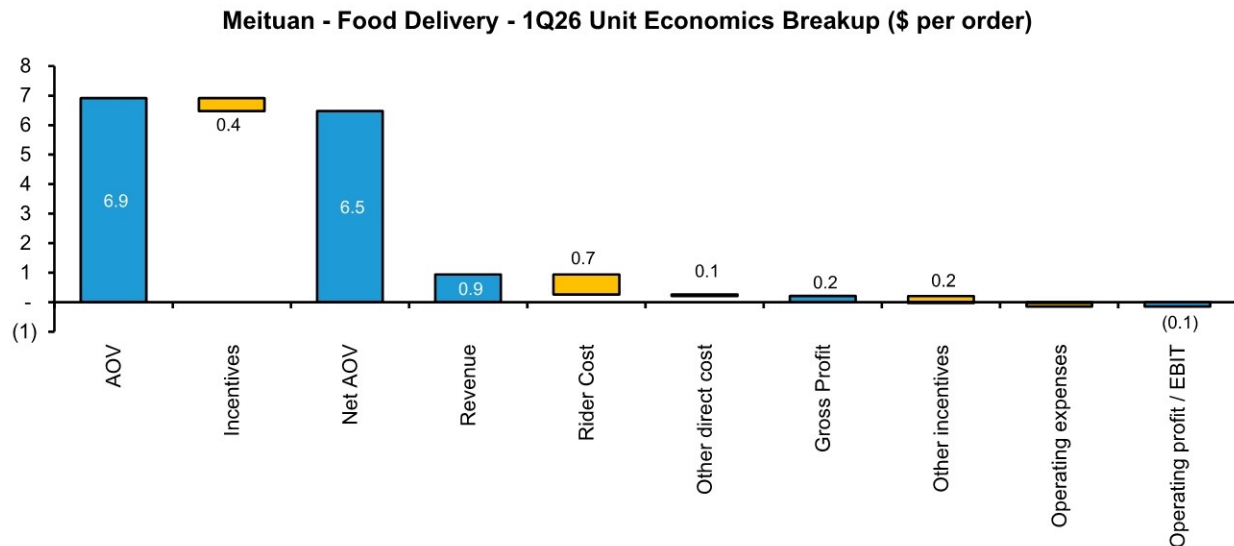
Source: Sensor Tower, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 19: The "FD" war resulted lower revenues, higher incentives leading to losses



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 20: On a per order basis, after a full year of high subsidies Meituan still lost ~\$0.1 per order (peak loss was ~\$0.4 per order (3Q25))



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

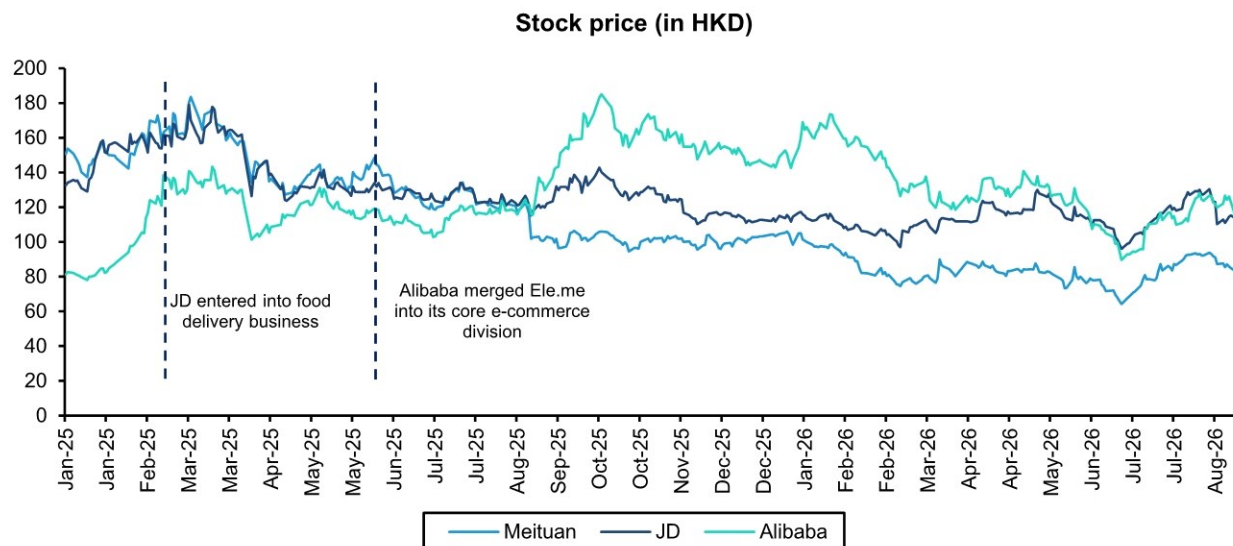
EXHIBIT 21: The cumulative operating losses of Meituan, JD and Alibaba over Q2 2025 to Q2 2026 stands at ~\$28 Bn



*For Meituan and JD, operating losses refer to the food delivery segment; for Alibaba, operating losses refer to the broader quick commerce segment, which includes food delivery ; USD/RMB exchange rate used for conversion is 6.72

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 22: Meituan and JD saw a derating as losses came in while Alibaba saw a rally as its AI and cloud story mattered more than the delivery burn



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

INDIA TODAY HAS STABLE SHARE BUT SEEING SOME EARLY SIGNS OF DISRUPTION IN APP USAGE

India's food delivery market has been very stable over the last 3 years : Zomato has held ~57-58% and Swiggy ~42-43% market share over the last 3 years ([Exhibit 23](#)). There has been two reasons for a stable market share (1) There has been no challenger with both intent and balance sheet to subsidize (2) The two incumbents have themselves stayed rational. This stability is what has produced strong unit economics for Indian food delivery players.

App usage data shows first signs of disruption: [Exhibit 24](#) shows monthly active user share across food delivery apps since 4Q F24. For most of the period Swiggy and Zomato together held a steady ~80% share of MAUs. In the last quarter this has dipped, driven primarily by Toing (owned by Swiggy) gaining users along with some early traction for Ownly (Rapido). We believe part of this disruption by Toing is the incumbent cannibalizing itself to reach lower AOV customers.

The Indian food delivery space looks ripe for disruption on paper, as we have written about it earlier also ([LINK](#)). Access to high-frequency touchpoint with the consumer, a healthy margin profile, structural growth prospects will all ensure that the industry keeps looking attractive to investors. And hence, either an existing digital commerce player or a challenger may keep emerging.

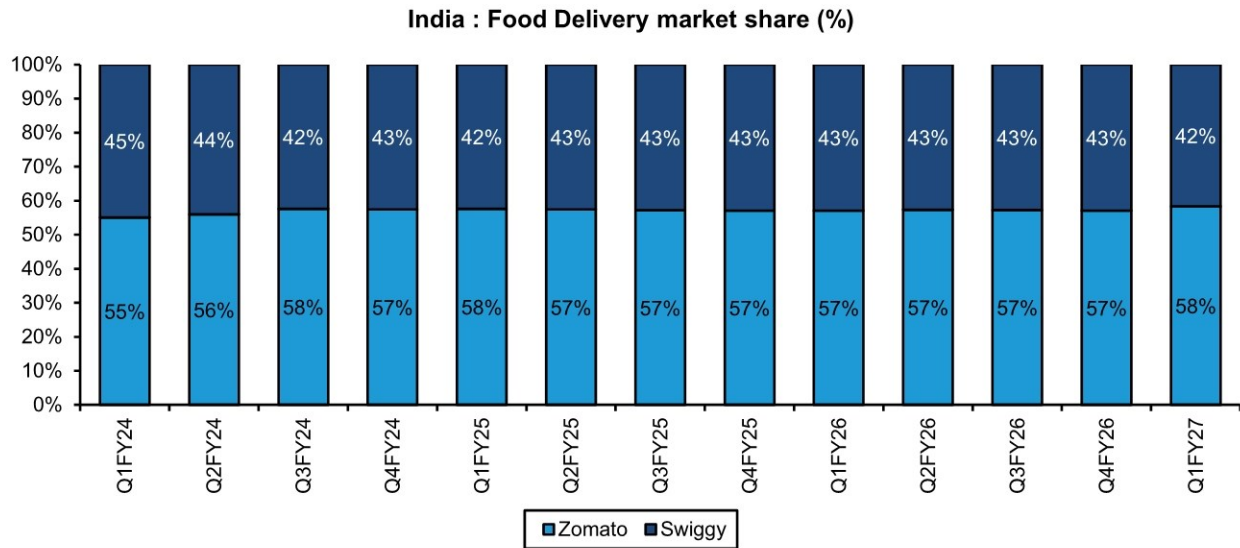
If the intent is to unlock demand at a lower price point and include more consumers into food delivery space, the challenger needs to solve 3 structural issues simultaneously -

(1) Food service demand in India is itself shallow, with only \$50-60 per capita per year of spend on average, due to cultural and affordability reasons. Any effort which assumes a rapid change at the industry level is unlikely to succeed.

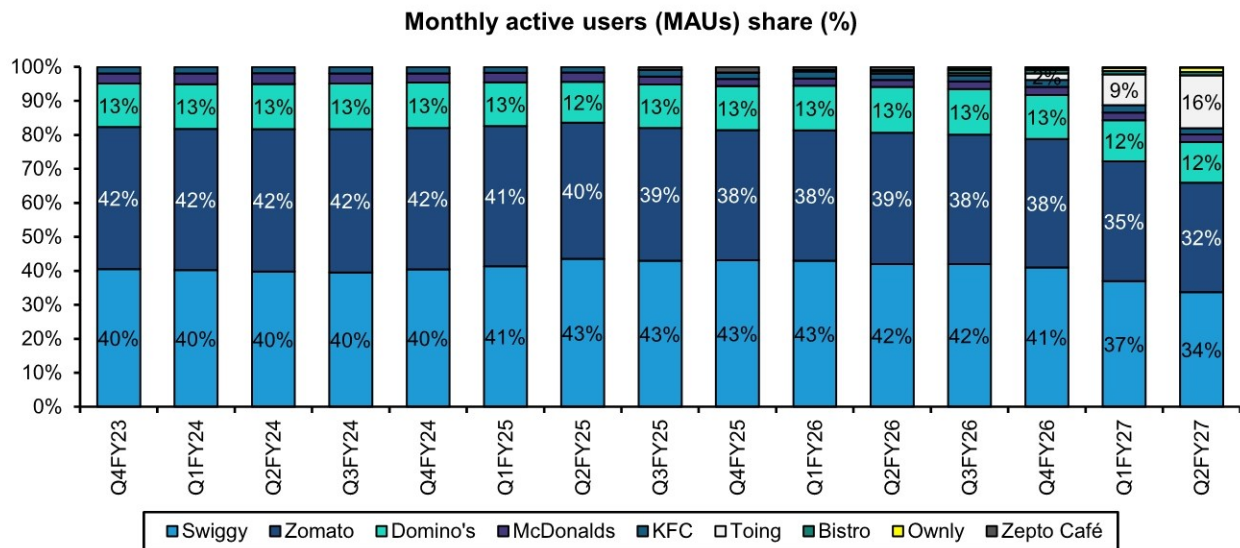
(2) The lower AOV demand is also concentrated in larger cities - putting a floor on how low the cost of customer acquisition and servicing can go to support the lower AOV demand.

(3) Lower commission rate alone is not enough to build a sustainable alternative business model. It will require a fundamental change in the cost structure, which is much tougher to achieve.

As of now, we don't see a convincing answer to these 3 points as an alternative food delivery business model. In a long-enough run, we see new players will continue to try to address this space and keep competition always on the horizon. However, the key benefit for Zomato and Swiggy today is that the size of the prize is small. Even if Food Delivery business model can be innovated, the depth of the overall food services market itself is very low - with AOVs of <INR 150-175 (<\$2) and low frequency of eating outside. Until that changes materially, the depth that an alternate business model could see remains limited.

EXHIBIT 23: India's FD market share has been very stable over last 3 years between the two large players

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 24: App usage indicates some disruption in the last Qtr, driven primarily by Toing - which is owned by Swiggy - seems to have taken share from both Swiggy and Zomato

*Q2FY27 is avg of Jul'26 and Aug'26 MAUs

Source: Sensor Tower, Bernstein analysis

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the "Firm" in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK (サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社) and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

Bernstein is part of a joint venture between Société Générale (SG) and AllianceBernstein, L.P. (AB). Unless specifically noted otherwise, for purposes of these disclosures, references to Bernstein's "affiliates" relate to both SG and AB and their respective affiliates.

VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Eternal Limited**

We value Eternal using a multiple-based SOTP applying a 35x FY29 Adj. EBITDA for their food delivery business, a 30x FY30 Adj. EBITDA for Quick commerce (Blinkit), a 1.5x FY29 NOV for Going Out and a 1.0x FY29 Sales for Hyperpure business, resulting in a target price of INR 350 per share.

Swiggy Limited

We value Swiggy using a multiple-based SOTP applying a 35x FY29 Adj. EBITDA for their food delivery business, a 25x FY30 Adj. EBITDA to Quick commerce (Instamart), a 30x FY30 Adj. EBITDA for Out of home consumption and a 0.1x FY29 Sales for supply chain and distribution business, resulting in a target price of INR 430 per share.

RISKS**Eternal Limited**

Downside risks:

1. Regulatory risks like GST on delivery charges, anticompetitive charges in food delivery, etc.
2. Faster and better than expected ramp up by competition in quick-commerce
3. Structural or seasonal disruptions in the delivery rider ecosystem

Swiggy Limited

Downside risks:

1. Regulatory risks like GST on delivery charges, anticompetitive charges in food delivery, etc.
2. Faster and better than expected ramp up by competition in quick-commerce
3. Structural or seasonal disruptions in the delivery rider ecosystem

RATINGS DEFINITIONS, BENCHMARKS AND DISTRIBUTION**EQUITY RATINGS DEFINITIONS****Bernstein brand**

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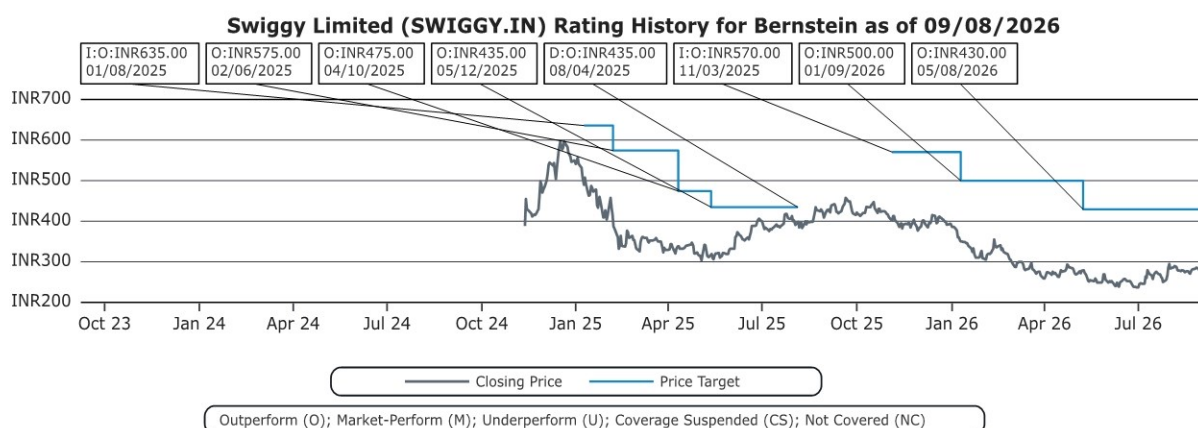
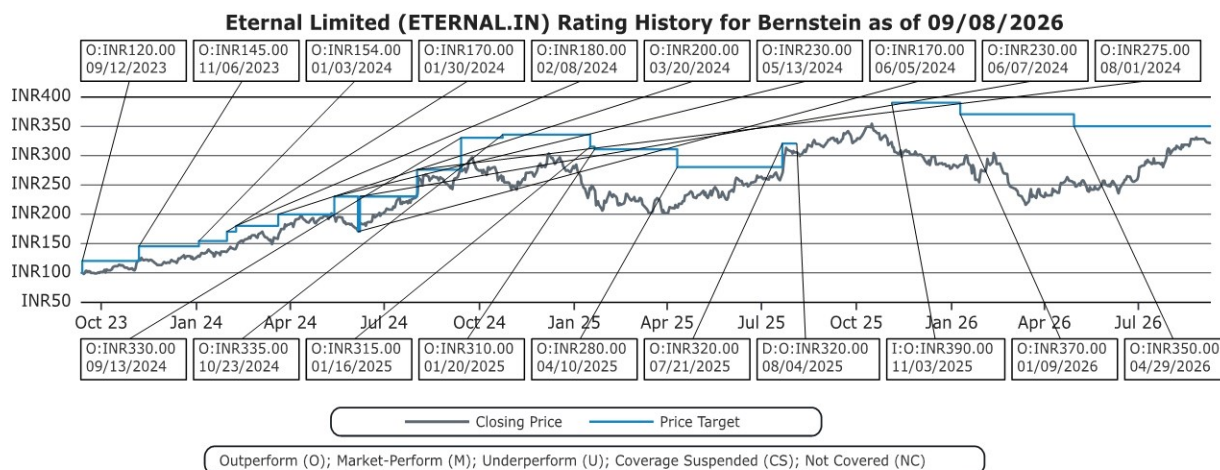
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